

A-LEVEL ACCELERATORS · FOR PARENTS OF YEAR 12 AND 13 STUDENTS

Why your child's A-level results *don't reflect their effort*

And what to do about it, starting this week.



By Dr Waleed Ahmad, MBBS

Doctor, former top-performing A-level student, founder of A-Level Accelerators.

Most parents I speak to describe the same situation. Their child is putting in the effort. Late nights, weekends, revision notes covering every surface of the house. But the grades aren't moving. They're stuck at Bs and Cs, sometimes lower, and nobody can explain why.

If that sounds familiar, here's the first thing to understand, because everything else in this guide follows from it.

Your child doesn't have a motivation problem. They have a method problem.

I'm a doctor. I can't treat a patient until I know what's actually wrong with them. Revision works exactly the same way. Most students, and most tutors, skip the diagnosis and go straight to treatment: more hours, more notes, more past papers. When the treatment doesn't match the problem, effort stops converting into marks.

I say this as someone who got into medicine with a revision method that was genuinely bad. I succeeded on brute-force hours, and I only learned afterwards how much of that time was wasted. Since then I've worked with over 1,000 A-level students, and the pattern is nearly always the same: a hard-working student who was never taught how exams actually reward marks.

This short guide gives you four things:

1. The real reason grades stall while effort goes up.
2. The four tiers of exam performance, and where your child is probably stuck.
3. Three questions to ask your child this week that will tell you more than any report card.
4. A free, step-by-step plan you can start tonight.

PART ONE

The real reason grades stall

A-level exams aren't designed to test how much your child knows. They test how well your child can **use** what they know, under time pressure, on questions they've never seen before.

That gap, between understanding a topic and scoring marks on it, is where most hard-working students lose their grades. Almost nobody tells them it exists. So they respond to a disappointing result the only way they know how: more hours on the same method. The hours go up, the grades don't, and everyone quietly starts to wonder whether the ceiling is ability. It isn't.

PART TWO

The four tiers of exam performance

The strongest students work across four levels of skill. Most students spend nearly all of their time on the first one.

TIER

1

Knowledge

Understanding the content. This is what school, textbooks and most tutoring focus on. Necessary, but nowhere near enough on its own.

TIER

2

Recall

Retrieving information from memory, under pressure, without notes. Exams test retrieval, not recognition. Very few students practise this deliberately.

TIER

3

Application

Using knowledge on unfamiliar questions in unfamiliar formats. This is where B students become A students.

TIER

4

Exam mastery

Timing, command words, mark-scheme language, and staying calm on the day. This is where A students become A* students.

Teachers and tutors cover Tier 1. The exam tests all four. *That gap is the whole story, and it's fixable.*

PART THREE

Three questions to ask your child this week

These aren't designed to add pressure. They open a conversation about **how** your child is studying, not just how much. The answers will tell you more than any exam result.

1**"After you finish a past paper, what do you do next?"**

Most students mark it and move on. Top performers do the opposite: they spend more time on the debrief than on the paper itself, working out exactly why each mark was dropped.

If your child can't tell you precisely why a mark was lost, they're practising without improving. The paper isn't the difference maker. What happens after the paper is.

2**"Have you ever written what you thought was a good answer and still lost most of the marks?"**

This happens to almost every student, and nearly all of them blame the topic. The real issue is usually exam technique: not using the examiner's language, not answering the command word, not structuring the answer the way the mark scheme rewards.

Knowing the content and scoring marks on it are two different skills. Most students are never taught the second one.

3**"When you lose marks, can you tell exactly why, and how you'd stop it happening again?"**

Most students answer with a topic: "I always lose marks on the heart in Biology." But examiners don't mark topics. They mark specific language, whether the command word was addressed, and how the answer was structured.

Those are technique gaps, not knowledge gaps, and they're fixable. A student who can't make that distinction ends up working hard at fixing the wrong problem.

PART FOUR

What to do next, starting tonight

You can't fix what you haven't diagnosed. Don't start with a tutor. Start here: all three steps are free.

STEP 1

Send them the Revision Diagnostic

Twenty questions, about four minutes. It scores how your child actually revises and sends them a report showing what to fix first. You'll both see the problem clearly before spending a penny on help.

alevelaccelerators.com/revision-diagnostic

STEP 2

Have them build their week with the Revision Tracker

They rate every topic honestly, and it builds a weekly plan around their weakest ones, with a proper method attached to every session.

alevelaccelerators.com/revision-tracker

STEP 3

Get them one good idea a week

The Sunday Session is my free weekly email for A-level students. Every Sunday at 5pm, one revision method, taught properly, usable that same evening.

alevelaccelerators.com/newsletter

When you want more than the free tools

Subject Accelerators

Live 12-week exam programmes in Biology, Chemistry, Maths and Physics, taught in small groups through the year.

Summer Accelerator

A six-week live summer course that gets Year 12 students ahead on the Year 13 material before term starts.

Study System

The exam-technique and revision-strategy layer that sits on top of subject knowledge. Tiers 2, 3 and 4, taught directly.

The first session of any programme is risk-free. If you're not sure what your child needs, book a free call and I'll tell you honestly, including if the answer is "just use the free tools for now." Any questions, just email me at Waleed@alevelaccelerators.com. I'm always happy to talk it through.

[Book a free call](#)